

c.500–600

First West African State

Rise of the Kingdom of Ghana, the first known state in West Africa. Its wealth comes from gold, traded across the Sahara with North Africa.

622–632

Birth of Islam

In Arabia, Muhammad, the founder of Islam, unites the previously divided Arab tribes under his rule.

618–907

Tang dynasty

Under the Tang dynasty, the Chinese conquer a great empire, including much of Central Asia. Chang'an, the capital, is the world's biggest city.

668

Korea unified

King Munmu of Silla unites Korea, which was previously divided into separate kingdoms.

632–690

Arab conquests

The Arabs conquer the Persian Empire and North Africa.

Flag of Korea

Tang dynasty, model of a polo player

789

First Viking raid

The Vikings stage their first attack on Britain, beginning more than a century of raiding.

800

Carolingian Empire

Pope Leo III crowns the Frankish (French) king, Charlemagne, as emperor. Charlemagne unites much of western Europe in his Carolingian Empire.

Viking axe and shield

1050

Printing invented

Printing, with moveable clay type, is invented in China. Earlier Chinese books were printed using carved wooden blocks.

1000

Vikings reach America

Leif Erikson, a Viking explorer, sails to North America, which he calls Vinland.

10th century

Arabic numerals

Arabic numerals (1,2,3, etc.) are first used in Europe. Invented in India, they are named after the Arabs who introduced them to Europe.

Statue of Leif Erikson in Norway

c.1270

First paper

People in Italy begin to make paper, at first from rags. Paper is much cheaper than parchment, which is made from animal skin.

1280

Polynesians settle New Zealand

Polynesian sailors discover and settle New Zealand. After centuries of travel, it is the last place the Polynesians discover in the Pacific Ocean.

1289

First eyeglasses

Eyeglasses are invented in Italy and are used to help with reading.

Maori man from New Zealand

1347–1352

Black Death

A terrible plague called the Black Death spreads from Asia across Europe. It kills between a third and two-thirds of the population.

1337

Hundred Years' War begins

Beginning of the Hundred Years' War, a series of wars between England and France that went on for over a hundred years.

1315–1317

Great Famine

Cold, wet weather across northern Europe causes the Great Famine. Crops fail, and at least a tenth of the population starves to death.

Rat fleas spread the Black Death across Europe.